

Open Forum

Imaginary Prohibitions

Some Preliminary Remarks on the Founding Gestures of the 'New Materialism'

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We have no interest whatever in minimizing the continuing history of racist, sexist, homophobic, or otherwise abusive biologisms, or the urgency of their exposure, that has made the gravamen of so many contemporary projects of critique. At the same time, we fear – with installation of an *automatic* anti-biologism as the unshifting tenet of 'theory' – the loss of conceptual access to an entire thought-realm. (Sedgwick and Frank, 1995: 15)

I was left wondering what danger had been averted by the exclusion of biology. What does the nominative 'biological or anatomical body' actually refer to? And what secures the separation of its inadmissible matter from the proper purview of Irigaray's textual interventions? When I asked a question to this effect it was met with a certain nervous comprehension. Deciding, perhaps, that I must still be immersed in a precritical understanding of the body, the speaker dismissed me with a revealing theatrical gesture. As if to emphasize the sheer absurdity of my question she pinched herself and commented 'Well I don't mean *this* body'. And so it seemed with a gesture so matter of fact that it required no further comment, the fact of (the) matter was both decided and dispatched. (Kirby, 1997: 70)

Feminism has been as deeply implicated in routinized antiessentialism as any of our critical procedures. Even though questions of 'the body' have become increasingly fashionable in all manner of feminist projects (surely 'the body' has become, in a very short space of time, one of our most routinized theoretical gestures), the schedule of feminism's antibiologism has been little altered. In most of these projects on 'the body', the body in question is pursued in its socially, experientially, or psychically constituted forms, but rarely in its physiologically, biochemically, or microbiologically constituted form, the idea of biological construction having been rendered

either unintelligible or naive. Despite an avowed interest in the body, there is a persistent distaste for biological detail. (Wilson, 1998: 14–15)

These feminist theories have usually been reluctant to engage with biological data: they retain, and encourage, the fierce antibiologism that marked the emergence of second wave feminism. (Wilson, 2004: 13)

That feminist scholars are particularly prone to a 'knee jerk constructivism' helps explain the reluctance of those in the humanities to engage seriously with the claims of science. (Squier, 2004: 46)

This book functions primarily as a reminder to social, political, and cultural theorists, particularly those interested in feminism, antiracism and questions of the politics of globalisation, that they have forgotten a crucial dimension of research, if not necessary to, then certainly useful for more incisively formulating the concepts on which they so heavily, if implicitly rely. It is written as a remembrance of what we have forgotten – not just the body, but that which makes it possible and which limits its actions: the precarious, accidental, contingent, expedient, striving, dynamic status of life in a messy, complicated, resistant, brute world of materiality, a world regulated by the exigencies, the forces, of space and time. We have forgotten the nature, the ontology, of the body, the conditions under which bodies are encultured, psychologized, given identity, historical location, and agency. We have forgotten where we come from. (Grosz, 2004a: 2)

In this position paper, I want to consider what it means for it to be routine to point to feminism as being routinely anti-biological, or habitually 'social constructionist'. I examine how this gesture has itself been taken for granted, and how in turn that gesture both offers a false and reductive history of feminist engagement with biology, science and materialism, and shapes the contours of a field that has been called 'the new materialism' (see Hird, 2004). **By constructing feminism as 'prohibiting' an attention to the biological and other matters, this new work is often represented as a gift to feminism in its very refusal to be prohibited by feminism's prohibitions. I will consider what it means for such a gesture to become foundational of a field.**¹—as in, what does it mean when we interrogate the claim that

It is important for me to state from the outset that the excerpts I begin with are from feminist scholars whose work I admire, and to whom I myself am indebted. I do not want to reduce this work to the gesture I am identifying. They offer us so much more than a gesture, and when I put that gesture to one side, I find much that is useful and exciting about these books. In posing these questions, my aim is not to dismiss specific feminist work, but to account for how that work might be gathering around a gesture, which if routinized, would have **problematic consequences for our understanding of the genealogy of feminist thought.** To sustain that gesture as a way of constituting a new field would be, in my view, a way of losing sight.

In offering this position paper, my aim is to open up a debate. In making a case, I risk overstating that case. I am aware for instance that begin-

new materialism rejects the primacy of language and representation in favor of the materiality of the biological. That these scholars state is messy & cultural feminist scholarship?

ning with a list of quotes that evoke this gesture, could be taken to imply that they are all making the same gesture. I think there are important differences. My point is strategic: the gesturing towards feminism's anti-biologism has become a background, something taken for granted as a common reference point such that it is not noticeable, and hence has not really been engaged with as involving a specific set of claims.

My viewpoint is partly a matter of an impression that has accumulated over time. I have had numerous conversations with friends, colleagues, participants at conferences, which have involved the use of quite casual forms of expression, which evoke a position that is not held by the speaker. One example of this is the expression, 'I don't think everything is just social', which has been repeated to me a number of times. The sentence works powerfully. It evokes a position that is not explicitly attributed to somebody as a way of making a counter-claim. In other words, it does not say, 'X thinks everything is just social and I disagree with X'. Rather, in evoking a position that the speaker does not hold, you evoke 'somebody' who does think everything is 'just social'. Who, one wonders, would ever make such a claim? Even if the word 'social' was not presumed to guarantee its object, to make that word a descriptor for 'everything' is not only counterintuitive, but also unproductive (as any word would be if used to describe 'everything').

I would suggest that the word 'social' here works metonymically: it acquires significance in part through its nearness to other words such as language, discourse, culture. **The speech act might express that familiar or even habitual anxiety that feminism and poststructuralism have reduced 'everything' to language and culture, in what is often referred to as 'textualism', and have forgotten the 'real' of the real world, or the materiality of what is given.** As a reviewer of papers for journals, I have lost count of the number of papers that have referred casually, usually without using examples, to how feminism or poststructuralism have not dealt with the body as a real, living, physical, biological entity or have reduced 'everything' to language, signification and culture. That these sentences are repeated without illustration or contextualization is symptomatic of what I call the 'routinization' of the gesture of pointing towards the anti-biologism or constructionism of others, whereby this anti-biologism itself functions as a form of bad faith (we need to be pinched, reminded of the real, returned to the facts of the matter). Rather than feminist anti-biologism or constructionism being routine, I want to focus on the routinization of the gesture towards feminist anti-biologism or constructionism. This is not to say that such a gesture is the only routine for new materialism; to make such an argument would be to repeat the very gesture I am critiquing. But one of the effects of this routinization of the critique of anti-biologism is that the critique of this critique risks being read as symptomatic of anti-biologism.

FEMINISM IS ANTI-BIOLOGY

Let's return to these gestures in their specificity. Some of them are specifically addressed to feminism (Kirby, Wilson, Squier), while others are addressed more loosely to 'theory' (Sedgwick and Frank) or 'social, political, and cultural theorists' (Grosz). We have a moving referent, or we could say that the object of critique is itself unstable. It is noticeable in the case of the first book quoted, by Sedgwick and Frank, that they do name a specific theorist and book: Ann Cvetovich's *Mixed Feelings: Feminism, Mass Culture and Victorian Sensationalism*. This book becomes symptomatic of a general trend in 'theory' to be, as they describe it, 'automatic anti-biologism'. Now, clearly they are worried by their own gesture. In a footnote they defend their use of a 'sole book as our example in articulating this argument', which they describe as persistence in 'gracelessness' (Sedgwick and Frank, 1995: 27). I am not concerned by their defence of the use of this book as opposed to any other book. But what is striking here is how this book stands alone: even when they comment on their use of this book, they still do not refer to other examples of 'automatic antibiologism'. In reading one book as a symptom of a trend, what are we doing? Does this allow the trend to be posited as internally coherent, framed by the edge of the book, as if it is a book? After all, the argument involves using 'theory' in quotation marks. Who is or does theory, one wonders? What about the work of science studies scholars who have worked on and with the biological, in different ways? Do they belong in 'theory'? I want to suggest 'theory' is being constituted as anti-biological by removing from the category of 'theory' work that engages with the biological, including work within science and technology studies, which has a long genealogy, especially within feminism. Such work disappears in the very argument that we must return to the biological.

For Elizabeth Grosz the argument is framed as a matter of return. We must 'return' to concepts of nature, matter, life (Grosz, 2004a: 2). That we need to return to these concepts, she suggests, is a sign of forgetting, 'we have forgotten where we have come from' (Grosz, 2004a: 2). One must wonder who is being evoked by this 'we', and to what extent this 'we' functions to interpellate the reader into a community that shares a common horizon (Have you forgotten where we have come from? Have I?). If you inhabit the 'we' of feminism, then you become implicated in this 'we' by virtue of your inhabitation. After all, this text is very much addressed to feminists and others who share feminist interests, suggesting that feminists, and 'all theorists interested in the relations between subjectivity, politics, and culture, need to have a more nuanced, intricate account of the body's immersion and participation in the world, if they are to develop political strategies to transform the existing social regulation of bodies' (Grosz, 2004a: 2). In other words, the point of 'returning' to biology, evolution and

vitalism (represented by Darwin, Bergson and Nietzsche – the book is primarily a close reading of these three writers) is to produce feminist knowledge that can enable political transformation. And yet if this book is as it were for feminism, then why does it not engage with feminism? Grosz does mention two feminist responses to Darwin, citing the work of Sue Rosser and Fiona Erskine. Grosz reads them both as examples of ‘the standard, knee-jerk feminist reading’ (Grosz, 2004a: 71) and although they are quoted, neither of the quotes is engaged with. They stand only as symptoms. She then suggests that rather than ‘providing criticisms of Darwin’s sexism’ (Grosz, 2004a: 73), she wants ‘to see what of Darwin, and the philosophical figures that follow him, may be of use to a feminist politics of transformation’ (Grosz, 2004a: 73).

What is striking here is how the history of feminist responses to Darwin is reduced to ‘standard, knee-jerk’ readings of pointing out sexism (read: automatic bodily reaction). The idea that such feminist responses are knee-jerk and automatic implies they are unthinking, perhaps even bodily responses that prove the truth of biology at the moment of its denial. I would argue that there is nothing automatic about feminist critiques of sexism. Indeed, this under-describes the philosophical and political contribution of ‘pointing out sexism’ (if sexism is structural rather than incidental to philosophy, as generations of feminist philosophers have shown us, including Grosz, then pointing out sexism remains a revolutionary and affirmative task, and a major contribution to any feminist project of transformation). It also does not appreciate the range of feminist responses to Darwin over time, not all of which were oppositional or worked by pointing out sexism within evolutionary thinking (for a summary of this range, see Gowaty, 1997).

Not only is the history of feminist scholarship on biology and science missing from *In the Nick of Time*, other than the two aforementioned examples of feminist critiques of Darwin, but Grosz does not engage with any of the more recent work within feminist science studies, which has engaged with the question of biology, materiality, life itself: such as represented by the work of Donna Haraway, Evelyn Fox Keller, Emily Martin, Sandra Harding and Sarah Franklin.² It is not enough to say that this is simply an omission (although as an omission it is striking), and incidental to the arguments of the book. Instead, the argument relies on the omission. **You can only argue for a return to biology by forgetting the feminist work on the biological, including the work of feminists trained in the biological sciences. In other words, you can only claim that feminism has forgotten the biological if you forget this feminist work.**

You could argue, as does Elizabeth Wilson, that feminism’s anti-biologism proceeds not so much as a forgetting, but takes the form of opposition to, and rejection of, the biological as a sphere of life, as well as a form

of knowledge. She represents second-wave feminism as 'fiercely antibiologist' (Wilson, 2004: 13). I want to comment, first, on the use of the adjective 'fierce'. The adjective is used of course not to describe feminists but to describe the anti-biologism that Wilson attributes to second-wave feminism. At the same time, this word evokes a caricature of the second-wave feminists: the fierce feminist tendency to be 'anti' is often evoked as some kind of pathological figure; she is angry, a kill-joy, perhaps even a freak. Elizabeth Wilson also describes such feminists as having a 'distaste' for biology. This description is deeply psychologizing, almost suggesting that the problem here is interior to feminism, as a kind of biophobia. The 'knee-jerk constructionism' that Squier describes translates this phobia into a tendency: the biophobia is what then would 'explain' the turn to constructionist models. Such a caricature of the second-wave feminist prevents us from engaging more closely (and perhaps generously) with the work of second-wave feminists.

Of course, many second-wave feminists did offer powerful critiques of the use of biology as a way of defending social roles ('biological determinism'). Their critiques were very important: there is no doubt that biology can be used to present social relations as products of nature not only within science, but also within government and public culture given the associations the word 'biology' has with what is given or already decided. But we do not need to read this critique as a rejection of the biological as such, but rather as a critique of the presumption that biology is fixed or decided. In other words, the feminist critiques of the uses of biology to defend gender hierarchy need not be read as symptomatic of anti-biologism, even if they are against a specific model of biology (just as the, critique within critical race studies of the uses of 'culture' to defend racial hierarchy does not mean being anti-culture, although it is anti a particular model of culture). After all, these points of critique of biology were always points of divergence between feminists, meaning that what constitutes 'biology' has been a question rather than solution for feminist thought.

In other words, feminists have produced very different kinds of critique of the role of biology, not all of which depend upon the rejection of the biological as a sphere of life. To describe the second-wave feminists as 'anti-biology' is a reduction of the complexity and heterogeneity of feminist work in this period. To say that feminism today has inherited this anti-biologism extends the violence of this reduction. Indeed, what is striking when you return to some of the feminist work on biology written in the 1970s and 1980s is the care taken in how the biological is evoked as a category. In particular, many feminist writers very carefully differentiate their object of critique from 'biology as such', whatever 'biology as such' might or could mean. For instance, we could read the following sentence from Deidre Janson-Smith's (1980: 65) article, 'What is Socio-Biology', as symptomatic of anti-biologism: 'The Women's Liberation Movement has with good

arguing for a
different model ≠
biological model ≠
anti-biologism or a
rejection of biology

reason reacted strongly to the use of “biological” arguments in the definition of the female; these have all too often been merely a confirmation of the patriarchal *status quo*.’ Janson-Smith does not address her critique to ‘biology as such’, but rather to the use of biological arguments to confirm the patriarchal status quo. She attends specifically to the use of genetic arguments. As she describes, ‘Inasmuch as we are made up of cells, controlled by genes, all that we do has a genetic basis. There are no learning processes that do not have *some* genetic limits, but there are few, if any, behaviors that are dictated entirely by the genes’ (Janson-Smith, 1980: 65). Janson-Smith’s work shows how the problem occurs when genetics is taken up as if it dictates behaviour, which is not to say that genetics does not shape in some way what we do. Speaking more generally, the problem occurs when biology becomes used as an explanation of behaviour, which is not to say that biology does not shape in some way what we do.

Feminist work on biology written during this period offers us a very rich archive of how we can think ‘this some way’. Lynda Birke’s *Women, Feminism and Biology* (1986) begins with the following statement: ‘this book is founded upon my belief in the relevance of biology to feminist thought: that relevance is not, however, biologically determinist, as I hope the following pages will indicate’ (Birke, 1986: x). Here the critique is directed towards biological determinism and not to biology as a sphere of life: indeed, the background to the critique is clearly an assumption of the relevance of biology. Likewise, Janet Sayers in *Biological Politics* (1982) discusses the ‘number of ways in which opponents of feminism have sought to appropriate biology for their cause’. As she goes on to argue, ‘although feminists have been accused of neglecting and ignoring biology, they have in fact suggested a number of ways of accommodating the facts of biology in their analysis of women’s situation’ (Sayers, 1982: 107). *Biological Politics* argues explicitly that the problem is with how biology has been appropriated to support sexism, which necessarily involves an assumption that biology is not itself inherently sexist.³ What is also clear is that the myth of feminism as anti-biology is itself part of the appropriation of biology. Sayers (1982: 173) notes how ‘writers have berated feminists for not taking account of biology’. The figure of the anti-biological feminist has a long genealogy, which is inseparable from anti-feminist uses of biology.

The point of the feminist critique of the appropriation of biology was to accommodate biology into an alternative analysis of women’s situation. Such a concern with accommodating rather than excluding biology as a sphere of life meant that much second-wave feminist thought offered rich analyses of human beings alongside other forms of biological life. For instance, Deidre Janson-Smith, who I quoted earlier, suggests that: ‘I see no reason to regard humans as other than biological beings, or to erect great barriers between humanity and the more “primitive” forms of life’ (Janson-Smith, 1980: 66). Indeed, although Elizabeth Wilson (2004: 1) chastises

second-wave feminism for being 'reluctant to engage with biological data', much of this literature involved very close detailed analysis of biological dimensions, often generated through a political as well as epistemic commitment to describing the biological processes of women's bodies, such as menstruation. Just note the detail in the following description, again taken from Janson-Smith's article:

There are many changes in the body's functions, as well as in the behavior that occur during the cycle. Brain waves (as measured by the electroencephalogram) are affected by the cycle, so that epileptic fits are least likely between ovulation and premenstruum, and most likely just before a period. Various other functions change, such as carbohydrate metabolism (the rate at which sugars are used by the body), thyroid function, mineral and water balance, resting temperature, and sensitivity to smells. (Janson-Smith, 1980: 98)⁴

This commitment to rich description of biological processes was generated by women's activism: the women's health movement, for instance, involved new understandings of women's bodies, which required engaging with the biological sciences often critically, but also very closely. **We only have to read *Our Bodies, Ourselves* (first published 1973) to see evidence of how this engagement with biological data provided a productive point of entry for feminist politics.**

As soon as we turn to feminist work on biology, the argument that feminism was anti-biology looks at best a caricature. If anything, we could argue that recent feminist work on embodiment is very indebted to this earlier feminist engagement with biology. To acknowledge such debts is not to prohibit critique. Internal critique is an important part of a feminist inheritance. But to caricature past feminisms is not to engage in critique: the work of critique is a form of intellectual work that requires engaging closely with a range of work (almost all the books I cite here use one or two examples of feminist or theoretical anti-biologism to illustrate their arguments). Many of the books referred to here under the rubric 'the new materialism' do involve generous forms of critique, but in relation to a scholarship they imply is insufficiently engaged with by feminists/theorists: **Tomkins is read very carefully by Sedgwick and Frank, while Darwin, Bergson and Nietzsche are read lovingly by Grosz. What is evident here is an uneven distribution of the work of critique, which is after all a labour of love. To be blunt, male writers (who are also usually dead and white) are engaged with closely, while feminist writers are not. What does this uneven distribution of attention and care actually do?**

It is possible to recuperate anything for feminism (well almost). We must and can make pragmatic choices about what to read, what to do with what we read, what we cite and how we cite it. I am not saying we should only read feminist work as feminists; that we should return only to this archive. And yet, there is a politics to how we distribute our attention. All I want to

suggest is that if we read the work of feminists writing on biology with the same amount of time and care, it might be harder to describe such work as anti-biologist. What is clear then is that the gesture of pointing to feminist anti-biologism either excludes feminist work on the biological from what counts as theory; forgets feminist work on the biological by arguing that we have forgotten the biological; or recalls that work by reading it as a symptom of anti-biologism.

When returning to these critiques of feminist anti-biologism, I was reminded very much of the evocation of political correctness as a form of prohibition against certain kinds of speech. In this argument, it is because of a habitual political correctness (the liberal intelligentsia) that we are not allowed to say this or that (e.g. a racist joke). The implication goes: by saying 'this' or 'that' we are fighting against the prohibition. The words become a symbol of refusing a prohibition and the justice of free speech. Perversely, this is how a racist joke can be spoken in the name of freedom. Not only can we detect here a structuring desire for certain words to be prohibited, but also an inflation of the very power of the 'whoever' that is doing the prohibiting: as if the world that says 'this or that is bad' is the dominant, hegemonic world, which demands consent. In this world, racism becomes the minority position, the racist, or the sexist, is the one who is not allowed to speak. I call this an 'inflationary logic'.

I would argue that the speech act that proceeds by refusing the prohibition against speaking about biology involves this inflationary logic. No doubt this is a potentially awful analogy. Let me say here it is not the content of the speech act that is imagined as prohibited that concerns me. Rather it is the form of the speech act itself. In both these cases (biological arguments against anti-biologism, anti-pc arguments against pc), **the speech act works by constructing an 'imaginary prohibition', which is then taken as foundational to a given speaking or intellectual community. That prohibition is imagined as hegemonic, as a majority position, in order to constitute the speech act, as a minority position, even as a kind of defence against free thinking, a rebellion against orthodoxy.**

The speech act that calls for us to 'return to biology' constructs the figure of the anti-biological feminist *who won't allow us to engage with biology*, and inflates her power. Let me give another example. Someone says during a seminar 'you have to be a social constructionist to get research funding from the ESRC [Economic and Social Research Council]'. The speaker makes reference to postmodern and feminist theory as part of his general critique of social constructionism. Actually, if we examine recent developments in the ESRC around requirements for social science postgraduate training, we might be tempted to say that the ESRC relies on a rather more conservative definition of what counts as knowledge within the social sciences. As a funding body, it polices what counts as social sciences, and excludes for instance any projects within women's studies or cultural studies

that employ anything other than what are seen as properly 'social science' methods. I have to confess I rather wish that the ESRC would be infiltrated by social constructionists, although I am not quite sure what they look like! For such a body to be identified as aligned with 'social constructionism', whatever that means, is not only fantastic, but also involves the inflation of the power of this theoretical framework, such that it becomes seen as defining the very material conditions of academic value. We are not far off here from the right-wing reading of academia as having been taken over by liberals and radicals who have turned away from the proper objects of academic knowledge. Again, one wishes!

Immediately, then, kinds of work defined as not social constructionist, not feminist, not postmodern (the slide between these positions participates in the logic of inflation) are constructed as the minority position, the injured other, as the 'who' that must be freed. The very gesture towards biology imagines itself as a prohibited speech act. Just as with the inflationary rhetoric of political correctness, we now have the defence of a return to biology (which is after all a highly funded discipline and a much valorized term within the general economy) as a form of free speech.

CREATING A 'NEW MATERIALISM'

Such gestures become foundational as they allow the implication that the theorist is embarking on a heroic and lonely struggle against the collective prohibitions of past feminisms. In other words, the gesture does something not only through how it constitutes feminism as an object (either in its presence or absence) but also through how it constructs the intellectual project of this new work. This work is often described as 'the new materialism' (see Hird, 2004). The new materialism does not take as its point of entry a critique or engagement with historical materialism, which does not haunt this emergent field even in its absence. Rather the point of entry for the construction of this field is the critique of past feminism for not engaging with matter, as such. The critique of feminist anti-biologism becomes, in other words, a more general critique of a feminist refusal to engage with 'matter as dynamic and alive', as Patricia Clough (2007: 8) describes. Feminism it seems has forgotten how matter matters.

This narrative of a forgetful feminism involves an emphasis on feminism as being 'limited' by its own preoccupation with culture. Myra Hird's account of the emergence of 'the materialism' has the following section heading: 'The Limits of Feminist Theories of Culture'. Within this section, she cites Elizabeth Wilson's critique of 'feminist analyses of materiality that remain determinedly fixed in the cultural domain' (Wilson, 2004: 22). We can see even in these two citations that the object of critique is unstable: in the first claim, feminist theories of culture are limited (as

they don't engage with materiality), and in the second, feminist theories of materiality are limited (because they reduce materiality to culture). So either feminism is limited given its emphasis on culture, or given its reduction of whatever it engages with to culture.

In most of these feminist critiques of feminism, Judith Butler is singled out as a primary example of a feminist who reduces matter to culture (see Barad, 2003; Clough, 2007: 8; Cheah, 1996; Fraser, 2002). It is important to note here that Butler does attend to the question of matter: she offers a definition of matter as 'the effect of boundary, fixity and surface' in *Bodies That Matter* (Butler, 1993: 9). For Butler, matter is an effect of a process of materialization. We should note, however, that her definition is offered within a specific context; at this point in the book, she is engaging with Foucault in order to reconsider how bodies materialize; and how sex involves a dynamic process of materialization. Within this context, her argument about materialization supports an argument about the sedimentation of bodily norms over time. She is not offering in this book a theory of the material world, but a theory of how sex materializes or becomes worldly. In my view, her definition of matter as an effect of a process of materialization, which is a theory of matter as temporal, could be used or extended to other forms of materialization. Butler does not do this, for sure; it is not her project in this book. And yet, her argument does not exclude this possibility even if she does not herself explore it. Butler is read as if she were offering a theory of the material world in the very critique of how she reduces that world to 'discourse' or 'culture'. In fact, if anything, *Bodies That Matter* offers a powerful exploration of how histories are sedimented in the very 'how' of bodily materialization: it makes sex material, even if it does not offer a theory of the coming into being of the material world, as such. To ask it to do so would seem unjust: as if accounting for the materiality of sex is too partial, not enough, insufficient. The reading of Butler as anti-matter seems to be motivated, as if the moment of 'rejection' is needed to authorize a new terrain.

The argument that feminism has reduced matter to culture, I would suggest, loses its object somewhere along the way. This is not to deny how much culture might matter for feminism. Given the feminist concern with understanding how gender and sexuality are reproduced in time and space, a key emphasis has been placed on language, culture, the symbolic, labour, discourse and ideology. This is because feminism needs a theory of social reproduction; of how particular forms become norms over time. But it does not follow that feminists don't then believe that the material world exists, or that feminist theory cannot admit to the materiality of things. If anything, given the concern with the social reproduction of hierarchies, much feminist work might point to the complexity of the relationship between materiality and culture, rather than reducing one to the other.

Feminist work in science studies, for example, which must be read as intrinsic to feminist theory rather than apart from it, explores the traffic between nature/biology and culture, as a 'material-semiotic' to use Donna Haraway's (2003: 201) classic term. The new materialism almost seems to return to old binaries – between nature/materiality/biology and culture in the very argument that 'matter' is what is missing from feminist work. This is evident in Karen Barad's work, an important commentator within this emergent field. Her paper 'Posthumanist Performativity: Toward an Understanding of How Matter Comes to Matter' (Barad, 2003) begins with the following argument:

Language has been granted too much power. The linguistic turn, the semi-otic turn, the interpretative turn, the cultural turn: it seems that at every turn lately every 'thing' – even materiality – is turned into a matter of language or some other form of cultural representation. The ubiquitous puns on 'matter' do not, alas, mark a rethinking of the key concepts (materiality and resignification) and the relationship between them. Rather, it seems to be symptomatic of the extent to which matters of 'fact' (so to speak) have been replaced with matters of signification (no scare quotes here). Language matters. Discourse matters. There is an important sense in which the only thing that does not seem to matter anymore is matter. (Barad, 2003: 801)

Barad is offering a caricature of 'the turns' in recent theory, although no examples are provided to illustrate the argument. We have no idea of who she is actually referring to (other than those who use 'matter' as a pun). Matter here is what matters, as a position that defends itself against theories that make what really matters (matter) disappear. She implies here that theorists are suspicious of the facts of the matter – but not of culture: as if now we trust in words, not things. We are thus scared by – we put scare quotes around – the word 'fact' but not the word 'signification'. So Barad (2003: 801) asks, 'How did language come to be more trustworthy than matter?' One could note here that the poststructuralist critique of language was that words are far from trustworthy, and that they do not give us direct access to things: I would even say that the poststructuralist turn begins with a suspicion with words as much as things.

This caricature of poststructuralism as matter-phobic involves a rather mournful lament: a call for a return to the facts of the matter that new materialism (rather ironically perhaps) shares with critical realism. We are witnessing perhaps an attachment to this lament. In Barad's paper, the caricature of whatever is the object of critique here (I say whatever because Barad, unlike other critics mentioned, does not name feminism, but simply evokes these 'turns' perhaps as general 'turns' within intellectual thought, using what I have described earlier as an inflationary logic) disappears as an explicit aspect of the argument. Instead, Barad creates her caricature by saying what she is not saying. So she argues against something or somebody throughout: 'Discourse does not refer to linguistic or signifying

systems' (Barad, 2003: 819); 'Discursive practices are not speech acts, linguistic representations, or even linguistic performances'; 'discursive practices are not anthropomorphic place-holders for the projected agency of individual subjects, culture or language'; 'matter, like meaning, is not an individually articulated or static entity'; 'Matter is not little bits of nature'; 'matter is not a support, location, referent or source of sustainability for discourse'; 'Matter is not immutable or passive' (Barad, 2003: 821), and so on. Her writing evokes the existence of an argument that discourse 'is' this, or matter 'is' this by arguing that it is 'not' that, where the 'that' is an argument that is not attributed to somebody. The new materialism takes shape by the mobility and detachability of this 'not'.

I would argue that the very claim that matter is missing can actually work to reify matter as if it could be an object that is absent or present. By turning matter into an object or theoretical category, in this way, the new materialism reintroduces the binarism between materiality and culture that much work in science studies has helped to challenge. Matter becomes a fetish object: as if it can be an 'it' that we can be for or against. What we might be encountering here is a desire for a pure theoretical object: whether that object is described as biology, matter, or affect.⁵ But such objects are invented, and when they are held in place then we are less able to do justice to the complexity of how all sorts of different things cohere. To include biology or materiality in the work that we do would be to give up the idea that they exist as objects that are given and which our task is simply to uphold.

Indeed, as I have suggested, earlier feminist work on biology and matter emphasizes precisely the entanglements and traffic between nature/biology/culture and between materiality and signification (see Franklin, 2003; Haraway, 2003). Indeed, returning to Haraway's monumental book *Primate Visions*, published in 1989, we can see the force of this commitment to thinking of the traffic between nature and culture. She describes the book in the following terms:

Primate Visions does not work by prohibiting origin stories, or biological explanations of what some would insist must be exclusively cultural matters, or any of the enabling devices among primate discourses' apparatuses of bodily production. I am not interested in policing the boundaries between nature and culture – quite the opposite, I am edified by the traffic. (Haraway, 1989: 377)

Haraway's work shows us how following the traffic means letting go of proper objects, including disciplinary objects: biology, culture, the social and so on. Things usually happen when the objects of our theoretical work fall apart, when things get messy. What counts as biology and materiality within the sciences is after all a subject of debate and dispute. New developments in thinking within all disciplines – the sciences, social sciences and humanities – often proceed from the collapse of their objects.

In claiming to return to matter, we might then be losing sight of how matter matters in different ways, for different feminisms, over time. The gesture is a forgetting as well as a caricature. Of course, I have no doubt reduced the complexity of the work I am engaging with. I was compelled to write this piece – by frustration, I admit. If my argument against such gestures means anything it means this: when we describe what it is that we do, when we consider how it is that we arrive at the grounds we inhabit, we need to appreciate the feminist work that comes before us, in all its complexity. We don't always have to make a return to earlier feminist work, but if we represent that work as being this or that, then we need to make that return. Such a return would be ethical: we should avoid establishing a new terrain by clearing the ground of what has come before us. And we might not be quite so willing to deposit our hope in the category of 'the new'.

NOTES

I would like to acknowledge my debt to Sarah Franklin: our many conversations on the feminist critique of feminist anti-biologism have shaped the arguments I develop here.

1. This gesture is not specific to feminists working in the area of new materialism. I have recently heard examples of this gesture in critical race studies, where scholars have argued that we need to return to the 'matter' of race, and get beyond the focus on race as construction or image, with its compulsive focus on racism as arbitrary. They often do so by representing other work in the field as prohibiting talk about biology and matter. One speaker at a conference even argued that Audre Lorde and Fanon reduced racialized bodies to 'body image' (which clearly neither of them do) and that Deleuze and Guattari offered a better alternative to thinking how the body comes to be racialized (as assemblages). For an example of this argument for rethinking the materiality of race that critiques other work for conceiving race 'as a problem of language' see Arun Saldanha (2006).
2. In *Time Travels: Feminism, Nature, Power*, Elizabeth Grosz (2004b) does engage more directly with feminist approaches to biology and Darwin, referring both to Janet Sayers' (1982) *Biological Politics*, and Patricia Gowaty's (1995) edited collection. She acknowledges that 'Some feminist theorists have made tentative approaches to a theoretical analysis of Darwin's scientific contributions' (Grosz, 2004b: 14). However, in both cases, she moves quickly to a critical language: Sayers 'sadly . . . leaves [Darwin's] social and political implications largely unanalysed' (Grosz, 2004b: 15) and Gowaty 'reduces both Darwinism and feminism to positions on two sides of a mutual divide' (Grosz, 2004b: 15–16). What follows then is an entirely uncritical and redemptive reading of Darwin, based on the idea that Darwin can give feminism something it lacks: 'we need to look again at his texts with the desire to see what they may be of value for providing feminist theory with richer and more subtle intellectual resources to both attain its aims and refine its goals' (Grosz, 2004b: 18),

which in turn positions feminism rather passively as a recipient, as receiving wisdom. It is also worth noting that in this book, Grosz suggests that 'it is only recently that feminist theorists in the humanities and social sciences have exhibited an openness toward biological research' (Grosz, 2004b: 217), which ignores the longer genealogy of feminist science studies: one thinks of classics such as *Alice Through the Microscope*, produced by the Brighton Women and Science Group in 1980 (Birke et al., 1980), which involves contributions from feminists based in humanities and social science disciplines; or books like *The Woman in the Body*, published by Emily Martin (1987), which contributed to the analysis of science as culture. Indeed, we could turn to the edited collection *Off-Centre: Feminism and Cultural Studies* (Franklin et al., 1991), which contains a section titled 'Science and Technology' (with individual contributions from Maureen McNeil, Sarah Franklin, Wendy Fyfe, Deborah Lynn Steinberg and Tessa Randles) and reminds us that feminist cultural studies and feminist science studies have a shared genealogy. We also need to recognize that many of the feminist theorists trained in the biological sciences actually work in, and contribute to, humanities and social science disciplines (e.g. Donna Haraway, Sandra Harding, Evelyn Fox Keller, Lynda Birke and Ruth Hubbard). The history of feminist science studies is exemplary as a history of the willingness to cross the borders between the humanities, social sciences and biological sciences. This interest in the biological sciences cannot thus be described as recent for feminists in the humanities and social sciences, though of course it might be the case that a more specific group of feminist theorists have become interested in biology and science more recently.

3. Reading *Biological Politics*, it was striking that 'biology' is not the only object of critique. For example, the use of biological arguments to support sexism is contrasted to the use of 'social constructionist arguments against women' (Sayers, 1982: 120). Indeed, if we think of the feminist critique of biology as part of the broader feminist critique of epistemology, then we can see how much feminism presses against the boundaries of all forms of disciplinary knowledge: including linguistics, psychology, history, sociology, economics and literature. Such pressing points are also points of engagement.
4. Or take Anne M. Briscoe's wonderful article published in 1978 on 'Hormones and Gender' which gives a detailed account of endocrinology, 'the study of the glands or tissues that manufacture chemical compounds (hormones) with special physiological activity and which release or secrete these agents into the circulating blood to influence cells at a distance from the cells of origin' (Briscoe, 1978: 32). Her account of hormones and gender attends to these physiological processes:

Those hormones that are concerned with sexual phenomena are also qualitatively the same in both sexes. They are produced and released by the following scheme: the pineal gland, which regulates the hypothalamus; the hypothalamus secretes hormones that regulate the rate of pituitary hormone secretion; the anterior lobe of the pituitary gland secretes hormones that control the gonads and mammary glands; the gonads in turn secrete sex hormones in response to stimulation by pituitary hormones called gonadotropins; the adrenal cortex or cortices secrete sex hormones in response to stimulation by another of the pituitary hormones, ACTH or the adrenocorticotrophic hormones. (Briscoe, 1978: 33)

5. I would also argue that recent work on 'the autonomy of affect', which relies on the sharp distinction between affect and emotion, repeats some of the gestures that are foundational within the new materialism (see Massumi, 2002). Elspeth Probyn (2005: 11), for example, describes affect as biology and emotion as culture, which creates a 'basic distinction' between biology and culture. While this argument is an important critique of the failure to recognize the biological aspects of emotion in cultural studies, or the cultural aspects of emotion within the biological sciences (Probyn, 2005: xv), it might be useful to challenge the distinction itself: to explore how culture and biology are mutually implicated; how neither are given, how they shape and inform each other.

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